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Q. In what ways can empowering women in food production and distribution contribute to improved food security? Critically evaluate social and economic impacts.

Approximately half of all agricultural workers in the developing nations, but they are systematically disadvantaged to be productive and agency-deficient. Female empowerment in food systems is not only a moral necessity, but also a practical approach towards improving food security, even though the correlation between empowerment and results is complicated and highly situational.

Food security indicates stable physical, social and economic access to sufficient, healthy and clean food. Studies reveal that an equitable access to resources between men and women farming communities can promote better farming practices as well as foster food security agenda within international arena. Agrobiodiversity relies heavily on women as they are primary caretakers of the knowledge on all types of crops, preservation, and local food systems. Women will develop more crop diversity when empowered, which will enhance dietary diversity and resistance to climatic shocks. They can also include them in distribution channels, cooperatives and market access programs to have shorter supply chains, less post-harvest losses and more equitable food distribution.

Socially, women who have control of resources and agricultural decision-making usually have the social priorities set on nutrition in the household resulting in better diets and development of children. Women who are empowered will invest higher in the education of their children and this will bring social benefits over a long period, and their participation in cooperatives increases the level of community cohesion and sharing of knowledge. The involvement of women in decision-making is something that contradicts the conventional gender roles, as well as promotes the principle of social equity. Nevertheless, these advantages are not universal and automatic. The economic demands that do not correspond with corresponding decreases in number of domestic tasks may overload women, which may hurt, instead of improving, wellbeing.

Economically, women empowerment in access to land, credit and agricultural technology will help to increase productivity and crop yield. Food insecurity vulnerability and poverty is mitigated by increased household income due to agricultural activities by women. The involvement of women in small scale food processing and selling in the markets diversifies the income sources and boosts the local economy. The presence in the market establishes resilience to the changes in prices and crop failures. However, still, there are great structural obstacles: the restrictive qualities of property law, the lack of credit facilities, limited mobility, and time poverty cripple the actual empowerment of women despite the policy intentions. Despite these barriers, the economic empowerment of families through supply chain and market involvement results in employment opportunities and increases their

resilience to shocks such as changes in prices or crop failures improving overall resilience and sustainability of food systems.

Empowerment of women can make food more secure by increasing productivity and resource distribution, although the long-term effect cannot be attained without a structural change, not only at the technical level. The key to success is a response to intersecting inequalities, reversing discriminatory social norms, a proper support system, and agency over women in determining their own priorities as opposed to forcefully foisting their developmental agendas.